

MEDIEVAL ENGLAND & THE STRUGGLE FOR POWER (1066–1485)

From the Norman Conquest to Bosworth Field: Monarchs, Barons, the Church, and the Peasantry



Primary Artifact: The monumental Norman Keep at Portchester Castle, Hampshire, demonstrating the military architecture of Norman royal power.

OVERARCHING HISTORICAL ENQUIRY:

"How did power shift in Medieval England between 1066 and 1485? Was the Crown all-powerful, or was royal authority repeatedly constrained by barons, bishops, and popular revolt?"

LESSON	HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & NARRATIVE FOCUS	PRIMARY SOURCE CORE	PAGE REF
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ENQUIRY 1 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 1: 1066 - WHY DID THREE MEN CLAIM ONE THRONE, AND HOW DID WILLIAM WIN?

1 THE PROBLEM: JAN 1066 – THE KING IS DEAD!

King Edward the Confessor spent twenty-four years on the English throne being deeply devout, famously distant, and disastrously vague about who would replace him. Having produced zero biological heirs, Edward spent his twilight years casually promising the English crown to virtually anyone who visited his court, setting up what would become the most vicious three-way geopolitical knife-fight in English history. When Edward finally passed away on 5 January 1066, Anglo-Saxon customs offered little guidance, leaving a dangerous power vacuum that three ambitious rulers immediately moved to claim.

2 THE THREE CLAIMANTS

The Claimant	Portrait	Who was he?	What was his claim (justification)?
Harold Godwinson	 Harold Godwinson Bayeux (Bayeux Tapestry)	The Earl of Wessex and the most powerful, wealthy nobleman in England. A brave warrior and brother-in-law to the dead king.	The Deathbed Promise: He claimed that as Edward lay dying, the King nominated Harold to succeed him. The Witan (the council of English lords) backed him, and he was crowned the very next day.
William, Duke of Normandy	 William the Conqueror Bayeux (Bayeux Tapestry)	The ambitious, ruthless ruler of Normandy (modern-day northern France). A brilliant and highly experienced military commander.	The Old Promise and the Broken Oath: He claimed Edward had promised him the throne back in 1051. He also claimed that Harold Godwinson had visited Normandy in 1064 and sworn a sacred oath on holy relics to help William become king. He got the support of the Pope , turning his invasion into a religious crusade.
Haralad Hardrada	 Harald Hardrada	The legendary, feared Viking King of Norway. One of the most famous and brutal warriors in Europe.	The Viking Agreement: His claim was based on an old, past agreement made between previous kings of Norway and England. If one died childless, the other would inherit both kingdoms. To make his claim stronger, he was joined by Tostig , King Harold's angry, exiled brother.

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Succession Crisis: A dangerous political vacuum caused when a monarch dies without leaving a clear, uncontested biological heir.

Housecarls: Elite, full-time professional Anglo-Saxon bodyguard warriors trained to swing lethal two-handed Danish battleaxes.

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

The Witan: The council of Anglo-Saxon earls and bishops with the ancient constitutional authority to elect and advise the King.

Feigned Retreat: A high-risk military tactic where troops pretend to flee in panic to lure a defensive enemy out of an impenetrable formation.

3 SEPTEMBER 1066: THE DOUBLE INVASION

King Harold Godwinson knew he was trapped in a geopolitical pincer. He spent the long, tense summer of 1066 camped on the southern beaches with his peasant militia, scanning the horizon for Norman sails. But summer winds blew obstinately from the north, keeping William’s fleet bottled up in French harbours.

Then, disaster struck in the north. On 20 September at **Gate Fulford**, Hardrada’s Viking battleaxes smashed the northern earls Edwin and Morcar, leaving York undefended. Hearing the news, King Harold executed an astonishing military feat: his army marched **190 miles north in just five days**, taking the Vikings completely by surprise at **Stamford Bridge** on 25 September. In a bloodbath so intense that only 24 of 300 Viking ships were needed to carry the survivors home, both Hardrada and Harold’s treacherous brother Tostig were killed.

Yet even as Harold celebrated his miraculous victory over roast meat in York, a breathless messenger arrived with catastrophic news: **the wind in the Channel had finally turned**, and William’s invasion fleet had landed at Pevensey.

SOURCE C

VISUAL FORENSIC ARTIFACT

c. 1070s

The Bayeux Tapestry: The Fatal Arrow & Senlac Chaos



"Here King Harold is slain: stitched in dyed wool, the tapestry captures the pivotal turning point on Senlac Hill. While nineteenth-century historians insisted Harold was blinded by an arrow through the eye, forensic textile analysis reveals the figure pulling an arrow from his helmet was heavily repaired in Victorian times. Whether struck by an arrow or hacked to pieces by Norman cavalry, the death of Harold decapitated Saxon command and doomed the kingdom."

Commissioned by William's half-brother, Bishop Odo of Bayeux, to celebrate Norman legitimacy while honoring the ferocious courage of English housecarls.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did the Norman conquerors choose to depict King Harold fighting bravely rather than cowering as a coward?

Bayeux Museum • Normandy, France

Anglo-Norman Romanesque Embroidery

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY

25 December 1066

ORDERIC VITALIS • ECCLESIASTICAL HISTORY (BOOK III)

THE SMOKE-FILLED CORONATION: PANIC AT THE ABBEY

William’s coronation at Westminster Abbey was meant to be a triumph of divine majesty; instead, it descended into farcical chaos. When the Norman bishop asked the English congregation whether they accepted William as king, the Saxons roared their approval in their native tongue. Hearing the loud shouts inside, the jittery Norman cavalry guarding the exterior panicked, assumed a violent rebellion had erupted, and immediately began setting fire to all the surrounding thatched houses in order to create a smokescreen! As parishioners fled the burning abbey in terror, William was left shivering on the throne before a terrified Archbishop Ealdred, clutching his holy oils and desperately rushing through the royal oaths in an empty church choked with blinding smoke.



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

DUKE WILLIAM OF NORMANDY ("THE CONQUEROR")

Duke of Normandy (1035–1087) & King of England (1066–1087) (c. 1028–1087)

Conquered England at Hastings, ending 600 years of Anglo-Saxon rule and establishing a centralized Anglo-Norman feudal state.

- Secured papal backing with a consecrated papal banner, turning his opportunistic invasion into a holy crusade against oath-breaker Harold.
- Famously pushed back his helmet during the panic on Senlac Hill, shouting: "I live, and with God's help I will conquer!"
- Crowned King of England in Westminster Abbey on Christmas Day 1066 amid smoke and rioting outside the abbey walls.

4 AN ENGLISH VIEW: THE ANGLO-SAXON CHRONICLE

The Anglo-Saxon Chronicle gives us one of the few surviving English perspectives on the events of 1066. It provides a brief but devastating summary of Harold's final stand.

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: Explain why King Harold decided to march immediately south to Hastings rather than resting his army in London.

2. Causation: How did Duke William exploit the Saxon shield wall's lack of discipline using the feigned retreat tactic?

3. Judgement: "William's victory was secured by weather and Saxon exhaustion, not Norman military genius." Evaluate this verdict.

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Medieval England (1066–1485)

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ENQUIRY 2 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 2: CASTLES, TERROR, AND THE DOMESDAY BOOK - HOW DID WILLIAM CONTROL ENGLAND?

1 CASTLES AS WEAPONS OF CONQUEST

After his smoke-choked coronation on Christmas Day 1066, King William faced an immense strategic dilemma. He was crowned King of England, but he was an alien warlord commanding an occupying force of barely 7,000 French-speaking knights in a hostile nation of two million furious Anglo-Saxons. If his men dispersed across the shires, they would be picked off one by one in the dark.

William’s solution was the rapid construction of an unprecedented weapon of terror and dominance: the **motte-and-bailey castle**. Using forced Saxon labor, Norman soldiers threw up massive earthen mounds (mottes) topped by wooden watchtowers, surrounded by a ditch and a palisaded courtyard (bailey). Built in under two weeks, over 500 of these timber fortresses sprouted across England, acting as impenetrable military bases from which mounted knights could ride out to crush local uprisings within hours.

2 THE HARRYING OF THE NORTH (1069–1070)

While castles kept southern towns intimidated, they could not prevent coordinated rebellions in the north. In 1069, northern English lords joined forces with an invading Danish Viking fleet, captured York, and slaughtered the Norman garrison. William was incandescent with rage.

His response was the **Harrying of the North (1069–1070)**: a systematic, state-sponsored campaign of scorched-earth terror. William divided his cavalry into marauding bands, commanding them to burn every village, barn, crop, and farm tool between the Humber and the Tees. Livestock were butchered, grain stores torched, and salt ploughed into the soil. Contemporary Anglo-Norman chronicler Orderic Vitalis recorded that over **100,000 human beings perished of starvation** in Yorkshire alone, with survivors reduced to eating cats, dogs, and human flesh. Seventeen years later, the Domesday Book still recorded vast swathes of northern England with one chilling Latin word: *wasta* (waste).

SOURCE B

CONTEMPORARY CHRONICLER

Historical Record

Source C: An extract from the Ecclesiastical History by the Anglo-Norman monk and chronicler Orderic Vitalis.

""He killed many people, destroyed the camps of others, harried the land and burned homes to ashes... At the height of his anger he ordered that all the corn and cattle, all farming implements and every sort of provisions and food be collected in piles and set on fire until it was all burnt. Thus was the whole region north of the Humber stripped of everything that could be used to support life.""

Contemporary documentation detailing key political actions.

Primary Forensic Source

Ecclesiastical & Royal Dispatch

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

Motte-and-Bailey: An early Norman wooden fortification consisting of a raised earth mound (motte) and an enclosed lower courtyard (bailey).

Harrying of the North: William I’s 1069–70 brutal scorched-earth campaign that salted fields and starved 100,000 Yorkshire peasants to crush rebellion.

Domesday Book: The unprecedented 1086 nationwide land, population, and wealth audit ordered by William I to maximize royal taxation.

Villein (Serf): A peasant legally bound to the land of a feudal manorial lord, forbidden to leave or marry without official permission.

3 THE DOMESDAY BOOK (1085–1086)

By Christmas 1085, William had crushed domestic rebellions, but his treasury was drained and rumors grew of a fresh Danish invasion fleet. At his mid-winter court at Gloucester, William held "deep speech" with his council and ordered an administrative feat unmatched in European history: the **Domesday Survey**.

Royal commissioners were dispatched to every shire, summoning sworn juries of local Norman lords and English peasants to answer meticulous questions: Who owns this manor? How many hides of land? How many plough teams? How many villeins, cottagers, and slaves? How many mills, fisheries, and pigs? What was it worth under King Edward, and what is it worth now? Compiled into a single manuscript at Winchester by a master scribe, the Domesday Book gave William total fiscal mastery over his kingdom. A peasant could hide from a Norman knight in the woods, but nobody could hide from the King's ledger.

SOURCE CADMINISTRATIVE MANUSCRIPT

Compiled 1086

The Great Domesday Book: Folio 44 (Hampshire Shire Inquest)

“TERRA ARCHIEPI CANTUAR. IN WARESTONE 1076. II. Auctore. Lantini tē in dno Godefrido. T. R. E. fe dēd p. quat. 33. hid. 7 modo p. xvi. hid. 7 una v. tra. ē .xx. cat. In dno fons. 1111. cat. 7 xxviii. uill. 7 xxv. bord. cat. xxxiiii. cat. In auct. 7 uill. mull. de. v. fol. 7 xiii. de pū. Silue. de. ccc. pū. De tra. lūq. 10. tē. Radulf. vii. hid. de archiep. Radulf. i. hid. 7 inde lū. vii. lib. 7 xiii. fol. de gabbo. Tūti T. R. E. 7 pū. cat. xii. lib. Mod. xxvii. lib. archiep. Humilly. cē. 4. lib. 7 x. fol. Ite archiep. tē. Cēna. de uill. monach. T. R. E. fe dēd p. xii. hid. 7 de p. xiii. hid. tra. ē. xiii. cat. In dno fons. 1111. cat. 7 xxx. uill. 7 xii. cat. cē. xxi. cat. In auct. 7 v. fol. 7 una v. tra. Silue. de. xxv. pū. T. R. E. 7 pū. cat. vii. lib. Mod. xiiii. lib. In BREXESTAN H. II.

"In Fareham, King William holds the manor... There are 30 villeins and 15 smallholders with 18 ploughs. There are 2 mills of 25 shillings, and 3 fisheries of 8 shillings, and woodland for 20 pigs. Its total value in the time of King Edward was £40; now £30."

Written in abbreviated Latin on sheepskin parchment by a single master scribe at Winchester, summarizing two million words of regional inquest data.

HINGE QUESTION: Why did the value of southern manors drop between 1066 and 1086 despite Norman efficiency?

The National Archives • Kew, London • E 31/2/2

Domesday Folio Record

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY

Christmas 1085 – August 1086

THE ANGLO-SAXON CHRONICLE (DOMESDAY AUDIT ANNAL)

"NOT EVEN ONE PIG ESCAPED": THE TERROR OF DOMESDAY

To English peasants, William's 1086 survey felt like the end of the world. Inquisitors arrived in every village, forcing sworn juries of Normans and Saxons under threat of torture to declare every acre of wheat, every mill, every fishpond, and every cow. The contemporary Anglo-Saxon Chronicle recorded the humiliation with bitter wonder: "So narrowly did he cause the survey to be made, that there was not one single hide nor a yard of land, nor—it is shameful to tell, but he thought it no shame to do—an ox, nor a cow, nor a swine was left that was not set down in his writ." The Saxons nicknamed it "Domesday" because its tax judgements, like the Day of Doom, were completely unalterable—once written in William's ledger, your taxes were fixed for eternity.



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

ORDERIC VITALIS

Anglo-Norman Monk, Chronicler & Historian (1075–c. 1142)

Authored the *Ecclesiastical History*, providing our most searing, vivid critique of Norman brutality and the human toll of the Harrying of the North.

- Born in Shropshire to an English mother and a Norman father, giving him a unique dual perspective on the Conquest.
- Wrote candidly that God would punish William for starving 100,000 Yorkshire peasants to death during the Harrying.
- Recorded the meticulous administrative terror of William's tax inquests across the English shires.

4 SIDE QUEST: THE DOMESDAY BOOK IN FAREHAM & STUBBINGTON

The Domesday Survey reached every corner of Hampshire, ensuring that even small coastal settlements were accurately recorded and taxed. The manuscript was written in heavily abbreviated Medieval Latin, making it almost impossible to read today without special training. Let's look at the actual entry for Fareham and Stubbington!

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: Why were timber motte-and-bailey castles far more effective for immediate conquest than stone keeps?

2. Causation: Explain how the Harrying of the North broke Anglo-Saxon military resistance for three generations.

3. Judgement: Which weapon of control was ultimately more powerful: the Norman castle keep or the Domesday Book?

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ENQUIRY 3 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 3: CROWN VS CHURCH: WHY DID HENRY II CLASH WITH THOMAS BECKET?

1

LEGAL REFORMS, ROYAL AUTHORITY, AND THE APPOINTMENT OF THOMAS BECKET

When young King Henry II ascended the English throne in 1154, he inherited an Angevin Empire stretching from the borders of Scotland to the Pyrenees. But England itself was a chaotic wreck following nineteen years of civil war (the Anarchy). Lawlessness reigned, barons built illegal adulterine castles, and—most galling of all to the King—the Catholic Church operated as an untouchable state within a state.

Under the medieval legal loophole known as **Benefit of Clergy**, any ordained priest, monk, or church official accused of serious crimes—including robbery, rape, or murder—could claim exemption from royal courts. Instead of facing royal hanging, these "criminous clerks" were tried in lenient Church courts governed by canon law, where the harshest penalty was usually prayers, penance, or defrocking. In 1162, Henry thought he had pulled off a masterstroke of political cunning: he appointed his chief drinking partner, hunting companion, and worldly chancellor, **Thomas Becket**, as Archbishop of Canterbury. Henry expected a compliant royal puppet.

2

THE BREAKDOWN OF RELATIONS AND THE CONSTITUTIONS OF CLARENDON

Instead of acting as the King's yes-man, Becket underwent an overnight transformation that left Henry incandescent with rage. Becket resigned the chancellorship, swapped his gold-embroidered silks for a rough sackcloth shirt crawling with lice, washed the feet of thirteen beggars daily, and informed his royal patron that God ranked infinitely above the King of England.

The collision peaked in 1164 when Henry issued the **Constitutions of Clarendon**: a sixteen-point royal decree demanding that criminous clerks convicted in church courts be handed over to royal sheriffs for secular punishment. Becket initially agreed under royal pressure, but quickly retracted his consent, appealed to the Pope in Rome, and fled into French exile disguised as a simple monk. For six bitter years, the former best friends conducted a vicious diplomatic feud of excommunications and royal counter-embargoes.

SOURCE B

CONTEMPORARY CHRONICLER

1166

Extract from a letter sent by Thomas Becket in French exile to King Henry II, c. 1166

""You are my sovereign and my king, but you are also my spiritual son. It is my duty to direct and advise you, not to be commanded by you in matters concerning the divine liberty of Holy Church.""

Contemporary documentation detailing key political actions.

Primary Forensic Source

Ecclesiastical & Royal Dispatch

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

Benefit of Clergy: A medieval legal privilege allowing ordained clerics accused of felonies to be tried in lenient Church courts instead of royal courts.

Excommunication: The severe spiritual penalty of expulsion from the Catholic Church, cutting off a Christian from the sacraments and salvation.

Constitutions of Clarendon: Henry II's 1164 sixteen-point royal statute attempting to assert secular Crown supremacy over the English Catholic Church.

Papal Interdict: A papal decree shutting down all church services, baptisms, and Christian burials across an entire rebellious nation.

3 THE MURDER IN CANTERBURY CATHEDRAL (1170) AND ITS AFTERMATH

In late 1170, a fragile truce broke down when Becket returned to England and promptly excommunicated every bishop who had taken part in crowning Henry’s eldest son. When the news reached Henry at his Christmas court in Normandy, the King flew into one of his legendary Angevin rages, roaring the catastrophic words: *"Will no one rid me of this turbulent priest?!"*

Four knights—Reginald FitzUrse, Hugh de Morville, William de Tracy, and Richard le Breton—took the rant as a royal order. On 29 December 1170, they burst into Canterbury Cathedral with drawn broadswords. Refusing to flee, Becket faced them by the altar of St Benedict. Le Breton struck with such fury that his broadsword snapped against the cathedral flagstones as Becket’s skull was severed.

The shockwave reverberated across Christian Europe. Miracles were reported almost immediately at Becket’s tomb, and the Pope canonised him as a saint within three years. Humiliated and horrified, King Henry II was forced to walk barefoot in sackcloth through the cobbled streets of Canterbury, submitting to public scourging by eighty monks with birch twigs. The King had secured legal power over his barons, but the Church remained untouchable.

SOURCE CILLUMINATED MANUSCRIPT RECORD

c. 1250

Matthew Paris: The Assassination in Canterbury Transept



"The knights struck with such ferocity that Richard le Breton broke his broadsword on the cathedral flagstones, severing the crown of the Archbishop's head. Monks fled in darkness, while Edward Grim stood fast holding the cross until his arm was shattered. Henry was forced to walk barefoot through Canterbury in sackcloth, allowing eighty monks to flog his bare back with birch twigs."

From the Chronica Majora of Matthew Paris, preserving the visual trauma of Becket's martyrdom for European pilgrims.

HINGE QUESTION: Why was Henry II forced to undergo public flogging if he had never formally ordered Becket's assassination?

British Library • London • Royal MS 2 A XXII

Canterbury Martyrdom Folio

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY

Christmas 1170 • Bures, Normandy

EDWARD GRIM • VITA SANCTI THOMAE (EYEWITNESS DISPATCH)

THE CATASTROPHIC DINNER TANTRUM: FOUR VERY LITERAL KNIGHTS

Henry II was famous across Europe for his terrifying Angevin temper; when thwarted, he would scream, claw at his face, and roll on the rushes tearing at the carpet with his teeth. Over Christmas dinner at Bures in Normandy, hearing that Becket had just excommunicated the Archbishop of York for crowning the young prince, Henry burst into an apoplectic fury before his assembled barons: "A curse! A curse upon all the false varlets I have nourished, who will leave me to be the mock of this low-born clerk! Will no one rid me of this turbulent priest?!" Henry meant it as an exasperated theatrical rant. But four of his fiercest household knights—Reginald FitzUrse, Hugh de Morville, William de Tracy, and Richard le Breton—took it as a direct royal assassination contract. They slipped out into the winter night, galloped across northern France, took ship to Dover, and rode straight into Canterbury Cathedral with drawn broadswords, delivering the English Crown the most humiliating PR disaster of the Middle Ages.



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

THOMAS BECKET

Lord Chancellor of England (1155–1162) & Archbishop of Canterbury (1162–1170) (1119/20–1170)

Defended ecclesiastical autonomy against Henry II's legal centralization; his dramatic assassination transformed him into Europe's most revered martyr.

- Transformed overnight from a luxury-loving courtier who kept sixty knights into a severe, ascetic monk wearing a lice-infested hairshirt.
- Rejected the Constitutions of Clarendon (1164), asserting that secular royal judges had zero jurisdiction over ordained Church clerics.
- Murdered at the altar of Canterbury Cathedral by four overzealous Norman knights on 29 December 1170.

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: Why was the legal concept of "Benefit of Clergy" such an intolerable threat to King Henry II's authority?

2. Causation: Explain why Thomas Becket's personality made compromise with Henry II virtually impossible.

3. Judgement: "By dying at the altar, Becket won a total victory over the English Crown." To what extent do you agree?

ENQUIRY 4 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 4: MAGNA CARTA (1215): A TRIUMPH OF LIBERTY OR A SELFISH BARONIAL POWER GRAB?

1 THE FAILURES OF KING JOHN: NORMANDY, THE CHURCH, AND FINANCIAL EXTORTION

King John was not merely an unlucky monarch; he was an obsessive micromanager with a remarkable talent for alienating everyone he met. Having inherited the vast Angevin Empire in 1199, John suffered a humiliating military collapse, losing Normandy, Maine, and Anjou to King Philip Augustus of France by 1204—earning him the sarcastic baronial nickname "Softsword".

Desperate to raise a colossal war chest to reconquer his French lands, John began weaponizing royal feudal taxation. He demanded **scutage** (shield tax) eleven times in sixteen years, extorted bankrupting inheritance fines from wealthy widows, seized the children of barons as hostages, and starved the wife and son of nobleman William de Braose to death in Corfe Castle. When John quarreled with Pope Innocent III over who should become Archbishop of Canterbury, the Pope placed England under a **Papal Interdict** for six years: church bells fell silent, church doors were locked, and English dead were buried in unhallowed ditches like animals.

2 THE BARONS' REBELLION AND THE SEALING OF MAGNA CARTA AT RUNNYMEDE (1215)

In 1214, John's grand military alliance was annihilated by the French at the Battle of Bouvines. His money was gone, his French lands were permanently lost, and his domestic prestige was completely destroyed. In May 1215, a coalition of forty northern and eastern barons renounced their feudal allegiance, took up arms as the "Army of God", and marched on London.

Recognizing he was trapped, John agreed to meet the baronial leaders on the neutral water-meadows of **Runnymede**, near Windsor, on 15 June 1215. The barons presented him with the Articles of the Barons, drafted into sixty-three legal clauses known as **Magna Carta** (The Great Charter). John was forced to attach his Great Seal to the sheepskin parchment. For the first time in English history, the sovereign king was formally bound by the rule of law: no taxation without common baronial counsel, and no free man imprisoned without lawful judgement of his peers.

SOURCE B

CONTEMPORARY CHRONICLER

1215

Extract from Clause 39 of the Magna Carta, June 1215

"No free man shall be seized or imprisoned, or stripped of his rights or possessions, or outlawed or exiled, or deprived of his standing in any way, nor will we proceed with force against him, or send others to do so, except by the lawful judgement of his equals or by the law of the land."

Contemporary documentation detailing key political actions.

Primary Forensic Source

Ecclesiastical & Royal Dispatch

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Scutage: A financial payment ("shield money") paid by barons to the Crown to excuse them from personal military feudal service.

Security Clause (Clause 61): Magna Carta's radical mechanism establishing a council of 25 barons with legal power to seize royal castles if John broke the charter.

Due Process: The fundamental legal principle that no free person can be punished except through fair, lawful judicial proceedings.

Angevin Empire: The vast collection of territories ruled by Henry II and Richard I stretching from the Scottish borders to the Pyrenees.

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

3 WAR, RE-ISSUE, AND LEGACY: LIBERTY OR BARONIAL SELF-INTEREST?

Magna Carta was never intended as a democratic bill of rights for ordinary peasants; it was a hard-nosed peace treaty negotiated by wealthy aristocratic barons to protect their own land and liberties. Clause 61 (the "Security Clause") went so far as to create a council of twenty-five barons empowered to seize royal castles and lands if John breached his promises.

John had zero intention of honoring the agreement. Within weeks, he dispatched secret couriers to Pope Innocent III, who issued a papal bull declaring Magna Carta "null, void, and shameful for ever." Civil war (the First Barons' War) erupted immediately. French prince Louis invaded England with baronial support, and John died fleeing across Lincolnshire in October 1216. Yet when his nine-year-old son Henry III was crowned, royal regents re-issued Magna Carta to win back baronial loyalty, ensuring that the charter survived to become the cornerstone of English constitutional liberty.

SOURCE C

CONSTITUTIONAL STATUTE

15 June 1215

Magna Carta: Clauses 39 & 40 (The Foundation of Liberty)

"Clause 39: No free man shall be seized or imprisoned, or stripped of his rights or possessions, or outlawed or exiled... except by the lawful judgement of his equals or by the law of the land.
Clause 40: To no one will we sell, to no one will we deny or delay right or justice."

Drafted in formal Latin on sheepskin parchment at Runnymede; of its 63 clauses, only three remain on the British statute book today.

HINGE QUESTION: Who did the barons mean by "free men" in 1215, and how did this exclude 80% of England's population?

The British Library • Cotton MS Augustus ii. 106

The Great Charter of Liberties

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY

June 1215 – October 1216

ROGER OF WENDOVER • FLOWERS OF HISTORY (MATTHEW PARIS MS)

STRAW-CHEWING, MUD & PEACHES: THE UNDOING OF A TYRANT

King John was an obsessive micromanager who spent his days checking treasury receipts and tormenting his nobility. When forty rebellious barons cornered him at Runnymede in June 1215, John was surrounded by armed knights and had zero choice. Chronicler Roger of Wendover recorded that after sealing Magna Carta with a forced courtly smile, John returned to his chambers at Windsor, collapsed onto the stone floor, and spent the night chewing furiously on straws and sticks, screaming that his crown had been stolen. His karma caught up with him fifteen months later: while fleeing northern rebels across the tidal estuary of The Wash, his baggage train misjudged the incoming tide, dumping the entire Crown Jewels, royal wardrobe, and golden plates into the quicksands. Broken and enraged, John arrived at Newark Castle, ate a gluttonous feast of fresh cider and green peaches, and died of violent dysentery at the age of forty-nine.



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

KING JOHN ("LACKLAND" / "SOFTSWORD")

King of England, Duke of Normandy & Lord of Ireland (1199–1216) (1166–1216)

His catastrophic military defeats in France and ruthless fiscal extortion provoked the baronial rebellion that forced the sealing of Magna Carta.

- Lost the ancestral duchy of Normandy and Anjou to King Philip Augustus of France by 1204, bankrupting the Angevin empire.
- Extorted massive inheritance fines, seized baronial heirs as hostages, and starved the wife and son of William de Braose to death in Corfe Castle.
- Forced to attach his Great Seal to Magna Carta at Runnymede in June 1215, then immediately persuaded the Pope to declare it void.

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: Why did the loss of Normandy in 1204 directly trigger the baronial rebellion against King John in England?

2. Causation: Explain the purpose of Clause 61 (the "Security Clause") in Magna Carta. Why did John find it so insulting?

3. Judgement: Was Magna Carta a selfish power grab by wealthy barons or a genuine foundation of universal human rights?

ENQUIRY 5 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 5: DOOM PAINTINGS AND TITHES: WHAT WAS LIFE LIKE IN A MEDIEVAL VILLAGE?

1 THE HEART OF THE VILLAGE: THE PARISH CHURCH

In medieval England, over 85% of the population lived in small agricultural villages called manors, where daily life was dictated by the unrelenting rhythm of the seasons and the heavy obligations of the feudal hierarchy. The vast majority of these villagers were **villeins (serfs)**: peasants legally bound to the soil, forbidden to leave the manor, marry their daughters, or educate their sons without purchasing a costly license from their lord.

Farming was organized around the **open-field system**. Rather than owning enclosed personal fields, peasants farmed scattered narrow strips across two or three colossal communal fields. This enforced strict communal cooperation: everyone ploughed, sowed wheat or barley, and harvested at the exact same time. Villeins owed their lord compulsory "week-work" (farming the lord's private demesne for two to three days each week) and brutal "boon-work" during harvest, leaving only spare hours to feed their own families.

SOURCE A

PRIMARY ARCHIVAL RECORD

Historical Record

Source A: A depiction of a busy medieval parish church.

""

This image shows the inside of a parish church with villagers gathering, trading, and talking, with no fixed seating in the nave.

PROVENANCE CLUE: This is a modern historical reconstruction based on descriptions from medieval accounts, such as Geoffrey Chaucer's writings, and archaeological evidence of medieval church structures. It is highly useful for showing the diverse social activities that took place inside religious buildings.

Primary Archival Record

English Monastic & Administrative Archives

2 PAY TO PRAY: TITHES AND THE CHURCH'S WEALTH

At the physical and spiritual center of every manor stood the stone parish church. The Catholic Church was not merely a place of worship; it was the wealthiest, most powerful landowner in the realm, owning roughly one-third of all English land.

Every peasant was legally required to pay the **tithe**: one-tenth (10%) of everything produced by their labour each year. The tenth sheaf of wheat, the tenth piglet, the tenth fleece of wool, and the tenth egg had to be carried to the rector's massive wooden tithe barn. Failure to pay was treated as a mortal sin that could consign your soul to eternal damnation. In return, the priest performed the seven holy sacraments, baptized newborns, married couples, and conducted funerals—the only gateway between mortal peasants and Almighty God.

SOURCE B

CONTEMPORARY CHRONICLER

Historical Record

Source B: A medieval record detailing the collection of church tithes from peasant families.

""Received from the manor of Elton for the year 1342: From John the Miller, 3 bushels of wheat. From Thomas the Smith, 2 lambs and 1 fleece of wool. From Agnes the Widow, 20 eggs and a basket of vegetables. All submitted to the tithe barn under the authority of the parish priest on the feast of Michaelmas.""

This text records the specific amounts of grain, wool, and livestock that each household in a local manor was legally required to surrender to the church tithe barn.

PROVENANCE CLUE: This source is an official church taxation ledger from the late fourteenth century. While it is highly reliable for showing the exact quantities of goods extracted from the peasantry, it represents the perspective of the tax-collecting authorities rather than the peasants who actually paid it.

Primary Forensic Source

Ecclesiastical & Royal Dispatch

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Open-Field System: The agricultural system where peasant villagers farmed scattered narrow strips of land across two or three huge communal fields.

Doom Painting: A dramatic, terrifying mural painted on the chancel arch depicting Christ judging souls into Heaven or the mouth of Hell.

Tithe: A compulsory tax of one-tenth (10%) of all agricultural crops, livestock, and wool paid annually to the parish Church.

Demesne: The land on a medieval manor kept by the lord for his own private use and farmed using compulsory peasant labor.

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

3 HEAVEN, HELL, AND THE DOOM PAINTINGS

Because church services were conducted in Latin—a language ordinary peasants could not understand—the Church relied on visual storytelling to communicate theology. Over the chancel arch of almost every medieval parish church hung a terrifying, full-colour mural known as a **Doom Painting**.

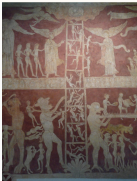
Dominating the wall was the Last Judgement. Christ sat enthroned on a rainbow, separating the righteous from the wicked. Archangel Michael held golden scales, weighing human souls, while grotesque demons dragged chains of screaming sinners into the fanged, fiery maw of the **Hellmouth**. Crucially, the murals depicted emperors, bishops, dishonest millers, and corrupt alewives all tumbling into the flames together, delivering an unmistakable lesson to illiterate serfs: endure your earthly poverty obediently, pay your church tithes, and obey your feudal lord, or burn for eternity.

SOURCE C

MEDIEVAL FRESCO

c. 1470

The Doom Painting: St Thomas Becket Church, Salisbury



"Painted across the chancel arch above the altar, this massive mural showed peasants exactly what awaited them at the Last Judgement. Demons with claws and horns haul chains of naked souls—including kings, bishops, and alewives—directly into the fiery maw of Hell, while angels usher the faithful into the golden New Jerusalem."

Painted in chalk and earth pigments; during the Reformation it was whitewashed over, only to be rediscovered in 1881.

HINGE QUESTION: How did the Church use visual art to control a population that could not read Latin?

St Thomas Church • Salisbury, Wiltshire

Chancel Arch Doom Fresco

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY

c. 1300–1400

PARISH CHURCH OF ST THOMAS • SALISBURY • DOOM MURAL

HELLMOUTH & THE SOUR-ALE FINES: THE VILLAGE SINS

Every Sunday morning, illiterate peasant farmers filed into their parish church and stared up in terror at the chancel arch, dominated by a vivid, blood-soaked Doom Painting. Christ sat on a rainbow, sending saints to Heaven and sinners tumbling into Hell. At the bottom right lurked the "Hellmouth"—a terrifying, fanged, serpentine monster vomiting smoke and pitchfork-wielding demons. To medieval peasants, this was not metaphor; it was immediate reality. The demons were shown shoving corrupt village characters into the monster's fiery belly: dishonest bakers who put sawdust in bread, crooked butchers who sold rotten meat, and "alewives" who watered down beer. Meanwhile on Mondays, the manorial court handed out real-world penalties: Alice the Brewer fined 3 pence for sour ale, and John le Ploughman fined 6 pence because his pigs broke into the lord's beans.



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

THE MANORIAL REEVE

Peasant Supervisor & Village Foreman of the Lord's Demesne (13th–14th Century)

Elected by his fellow serfs but answerable to the bailiff, the reeve balanced the daily survival of villagers against the lord's demands.

- Supervised compulsory week-work, ensuring peasants ploughed, sowed, and harvested the lord's strips before tending their own.
- Inspected tithe deliveries to the parish church, ensuring every tenth sheaf of wheat was delivered to the rector's barn.
- Reported village infractions to the manorial court, from stray pigs rooting in barley to brewers selling sour ale.

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: Explain how the three-field open-strip farming system prevented any individual peasant from starving.

2. Causation: Why was the payment of the tithe (10% of all produce) such a heavy financial burden on medieval villeins?

3. Judgement: How did fear of Purgatory and Hell reinforce the feudal social hierarchy of medieval England?

ENQUIRY 6 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 6: 1348: HOW DID THE BLACK DEATH SHATTER MEDIEVAL SOCIAL ORDER?

1 ARRIVAL, SYMPTOMS, AND DEVASTATION: THE TERROR OF 1348

In June 1348, a merchant vessel from Gascony docked at the Dorset port of Melcombe Regis (modern Weymouth), carrying fine wines and a lethal passenger: black rats carrying fleas infected with the bacterium *Yersinia pestis*. Within weeks, the **Black Death** was rampaging across southern England with catastrophic velocity.

The pestilence struck in two horrifying forms: **bubonic plague**, which caused agonizing, egg-sized swellings (buboes) in the groin and armpits that turned black and burst with foul pus, killing within five days; and **pneumonic plague**, which attacked the lungs, causing victims to cough up blood and die within twenty-four hours. Lacking any scientific knowledge of microbes, people believed the plague was caused by "corrupt miasma air" or God's divine wrath. Between 1348 and 1350, roughly **30% to 45% of England's population died**—nearly two million human beings.

2 ECONOMIC CRISIS AND THE STATUTE OF LABOURERS (1351)

The sudden death of millions of working people triggered an economic earthquake that shattered the foundations of feudalism. In villages across the country, unharvested crops rotted in muddy fields and cattle wandered through abandoned cottages. For surviving lords, the crisis was existential: there were suddenly far more fields than labourers to work them.

For the first time in medieval history, surviving peasant serfs realized they possessed immense economic bargaining power. They demanded higher cash wages, lower rents, and the abolition of hated villeinage duties. When lords refused, peasants simply packed their tools and walked to neighboring manors that offered double wages.

Terrified of this working-class empowerment, the aristocratic landowners in Parliament struck back. In 1351, they passed the **Statute of Labourers**, ordering that peasant wages be frozen at pre-plague 1346 levels and imposing prison sentences on any worker who refused to labor at the old rates. It was an impossible law that generated thirty years of simmering rural fury.

SOURCE B

CONTEMPORARY CHRONICLER

1351

Extract from the Statute of Labourers, 1351

"Because a great part of the people, and especially of workmen and servants, late died at the pestilence, many seeing the necessity of masters, and great scarcity of servants, will not serve unless they may receive excessive wages... We have ordained that every man and woman in our realm... shall be bounden to serve him which shall require him, and take only the wages, livery, or salary, which were accustomed to be given in the places where he oweth to serve, the twentieth year of our reign of England [1346]."

Contemporary documentation detailing key political actions.

Primary Forensic Source

Ecclesiastical & Royal Dispatch

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

Bubonic Plague: A lethal bacterial infection caused by "Yersinia pestis", transmitted by black rat fleas and causing swollen, agonizing buboes.

Statute of Labourers (1351): A harsh parliamentary law passed by landowning lords attempting to freeze peasant wages at pre-plague 1346 levels.

Miasma Theory: The prevailing medieval medical belief that infectious diseases were caused by poisonous, foul vapors rising from rotting matter.

Danse Macabre: The post-plague cultural motif ("Dance of Death") showing personified Death dancing with popes, kings, and peasants alike.

3 THE COLLAPSE OF FEUDALISM AND THE PSYCHOLOGICAL SHIFT

The psychological impact of the pestilence went far deeper than wages and farm labour. The Church, which had claimed to hold the keys to divine salvation, proved completely powerless to halt the dying; bishops fled their palaces, and in many parishes, priests abandoned dying parishioners for fear of catching the infection. To fill the void, the Church was forced to ordain teenage boys and illiterate clerks, severely damaging ecclesiastical prestige.

A dark, morbid fatalism gripped European culture. Art and literature were overtaken by the **Danse Macabre (Dance of Death)**: skeletons dancing hand-in-hand with popes, kings, knights, and ploughmen alike. The medieval social contract was broken: if Death treated prince and peasant as absolute equals, why should the feudal order remain intact?

SOURCE C ILLUMINATED CHRONICLE

c. 1350

Gilles li Muisis: Mass Plague Burials in Tournai



"No bells tolled, and no one wept; for almost all expected death... People said and believed: 'This is the end of the world.' So many died that trenches had to be dug in cemeteries and bodies piled forty deep. A dead man was then of no more account than a dead goat."

From the Annals of Abbot Gilles li Muisis, documenting the psychological collapse and breakdown of Christian funeral rites.

HINGE QUESTION: How did the collapse of normal burial ceremonies shatter medieval religious certainty?

Bibliothèque Royale de Belgique • Brussels • MS 13076

Chronicle of Gilles li Muisis

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY Autumn 1348 – Summer 1349

HENRY KNIGHTON • CHRONICON (LEICESTER ABBEY MANUSCRIPT)

SHAVED CHICKENS, LATRINE PITS & FLAGELLANTS

Confronted with a pandemic that killed within seventy-two hours, medieval physicians were utterly clueless. Operating under Galenic miasma theory, they believed plague was caused by "bad air" stirred up by earthquakes or planetary alignments. Doctors advised patients to carry sweet-smelling posies of herbs or—in bizarre desperation—to sit over open cesspits to inhale latrine vapours, believing "strong foul air would drive out weaker plague air." Another popular folk remedy was the "chicken cure": pluck the feathers off the backside of a live chicken and strap it directly to an agonizing, egg-sized bubo in the groin until the bird died, supposedly drawing out the venom. Meanwhile through the muddy streets stumbled processions of Flagellants—fanatical religious zealots who whipped their bare shoulders with iron-tipped scourges until blood drenched their robes, screaming that the apocalypse had arrived and God was punishing England for vanity.



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

HENRY KNIGHTON

Augustinian Canon of St Mary de Pratis Abbey, Leicester (Died c. 1396)

Eyewitness chronicler of the Black Death; recorded both the horrifying mortality rate and the sudden economic empowerment of surviving labourers.

- Documented the terrifying speed of bubonic and pneumonic infection as it swept through Leicestershire in 1348–49.
- Recorded the agricultural standstill: unharvested wheat rotting in rain-soaked fields and cattle wandering through towns.
- Wrote indignantly of surviving peasants who refused to work unless paid double or triple their pre-plague wages.

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: Why did the death of 30–45% of England's population create a catastrophic labour shortage for manorial lords?

2. Causation: Explain why Parliament passed the Statute of Labourers in 1351. Why were peasants so furious about it?

3. Judgement: "The Black Death destroyed the feudal system far more effectively than any army." Assess this judgement.

ENQUIRY 7 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 7: 1381: WHY DID THE PEASANTS REVOLT, AND DID THEY ACHIEVE ANYTHING?

1 CAUSES OF THE REVOLT: THE POLL TAX, LABOUR LAWS, AND RADICAL PREACHING

By 1381, England was a pressure cooker of working-class grievance. For thirty years, peasants had endured the humiliating wage caps of the Statute of Labourers, watched landlords pass **Sumptuary Laws** dictating what fabrics and furs ordinary people were legally allowed to wear, and listened to radical hedge-priests like **Father John Ball** preaching equality on village greens: *"When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?"*

The final spark was the catastrophic **Poll Taxes of 1377–1381**. To finance an expensive and losing war against France, the government of fourteen-year-old King Richard II levied a flat-rate direct tax of 12 pence on every single adult in the kingdom—regardless of whether they were a wealthy merchant or a starving ploughman. It was blatantly regressive and universally loathed.

SOURCE A

PRIMARY ARCHIVAL RECORD

Historical Record

Extract from a sermon by John Ball, recorded in Jean Froissart's Chronicles

"My friends, the state of England cannot be right until everything is held in common and there is no difference between nobleman and peasant and we are all as one. Why do nobles lord it over us? We are all descended from our first parents, Adam and Eve, so how can they be better men than us?"

Verbatim primary testimony from the period.

Primary Archival Record

English Monastic & Administrative Archives

2 THE UPRISING: WAT TYLER, MARCH ON LONDON, AND THE FALL OF THE TOWER

In May 1381, armed violence erupted in the Essex village of Fobbing when villagers violently attacked a royal tax commissioner and threw him out of town. Within days, the rebellion ignited across Kent, Essex, and East Anglia, uniting over 60,000 peasants under the charismatic leadership of a former soldier named **Wat Tyler**.

Armed with scythes, rusty swords, and longbows, the peasant army converged on London. Sympathetic London apprentices opened the city gates on 13 June, and the rebels unleashed calculated fury: they torched the luxury Savoy Palace belonging to the King's hated uncle John of Gaunt, broke open the Marshalsea prison, and systematically burned manorial court rolls and tax registers. On 14 June, rebels stormed the Tower of London, dragged out Archbishop Simon Sudbury (the King's Chancellor) and Sir Robert Hales (the Treasurer), and beheaded them on Tower Hill.

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

Poll Tax: A flat-rate direct tax levied on every individual adult regardless of wealth, triggering universal working-class fury in 1381.

Sumptuary Laws: Parliamentary statutes regulating the clothing, furs, and food different social classes were legally permitted to consume.

Manorial Rolls: Vellum legal court registers recording the names, land debts, and villeinage obligations of peasants, burned by 1381 rebels.

Egalitarianism: The radical political philosophy preached by John Ball asserting that all human beings are created naturally equal by God.

3 SMITHFIELD, ROYAL TREACHERY, AND THE LONG-TERM AFTERMATH

On 15 June 1381, King Richard II agreed to meet Wat Tyler and the rebel leaders at Smithfield cattle market outside the city walls. Tyler demanded the total abolition of serfdom, the repeal of all labour laws, the confiscation of church wealth, and complete equality of all men under the king.

During the tense negotiations, Mayor of London William Walworth took offence at Tyler's insolent manner, drew his dagger, and mortally wounded the peasant leader. As Tyler fell from his horse and thousands of rebel archers drew their bowstrings to shoot the royal party, fourteen-year-old Richard II rode boldly forward alone into no-man's-land, shouting: *"Peace! Tyler was a traitor. I am your king! I will be your captain; follow me into the field!"*

Enchanted by royal majesty and trusting the boy king's promises of total pardon, the peasants disbanded and marched home. It was a cold-blooded royal deception. As soon as loyal aristocratic knights arrived in London, Richard dispatched death squads and royal judges to hang over 1,500 rebel leaders across the shires, revoking every promise with the chilling words: *"Villeins you were, and villeins you shall remain; in bondage, but incomparably viler."* Yet despite the brutal repression, no government ever dared levy a Poll Tax again, and villeinage quietly withered away over the next century.

SOURCE C ILLUMINATED CHRONICLE

c. 1470s

Jean Froissart: The Murder of Wat Tyler at Smithfield



"Tyler said to the King: 'Thinkest thou that I will take thy word?' The Mayor of London drew his sword and struck Tyler such a blow on the head that he fell from his horse to the ground... The King said: 'Sirs, will you shoot your King? I am your captain, follow me!'"

From the Chronicles of Jean Froissart, an aristocrat-friendly chronicler who portrayed the peasants as unruly beasts.

HINGE QUESTION: How does Froissart's wealthy background bias his description of Wat Tyler's actions?

British Library • London • Royal MS 18 E. I

Froissart's Chronicles of England and France

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY 14–15 June 1381 • London

THE ANONIMALLE CHRONICLE OF ST MARY'S • YORK (C. 1390)

A SEVERED HEAD AT THE TOWER & A 14-YEAR-OLD'S CYNICAL OATH

When the peasant army flooded London, they bypassed the royal guards at the Tower of London and dragged out Archbishop Sudbury (who was also the King's Chancellor responsible for the hated Poll Tax). Taking eight messy axe blows to sever his head, the rebels paraded it through Cheapside on a pike before supposedly playing a game of football with it in the gutter. The next afternoon at Smithfield, fourteen-year-old King Richard II faced Wat Tyler. Tyler, emboldened by power, rode up, spat water at the King's feet, and washed his mouth in beer. London Mayor William Walworth, furious at such peasant disrespect, drew his baselard dagger and slashed Tyler across the neck. As the peasant archers notched their arrows to slaughter the royal party, young Richard galloped alone toward the angry rebels, shouting: *"I am your king! I will be your captain! Follow me into the field!"* The peasants cheered, believed him, and went home in peace. Within a month, Richard sent royal judges and soldiers to hang 1,500 rebels, delivering his infamous verdict: *"Villeins you were, and villeins you shall remain."*



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE WAT TYLER & JOHN BALL

Leaders of the 1381 Great Uprising (Tyler (d. 1381) • Ball (c. 1338–1381))

Led England's first major popular revolution, capturing London and demanding the total abolition of serfdom and equality under the law.

- John Ball preached radical equality at Blackheath: *"When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?"*
- Tyler led 60,000 peasants from Kent and Essex into London, burning the Savoy Palace and executing the King's treasurer.
- Met King Richard II at Mile End and Smithfield, demanding the end of villeinage and freedom of trade across England.

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: Why did the Poll Taxes of 1377–1381 trigger far greater fury than traditional taxes on land and property?

2. Causation: Explain why the peasants burned legal manorial court rolls and tax ledgers when they reached London.

3. Judgement: Did the Peasants' Revolt achieve anything, or was it an utter failure crushed by royal betrayal?

ENQUIRY 8 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 8: THE WARS OF THE ROSES (1455–1485) - HOW DID THE MEDIEVAL ERA END IN BLOOD?

1 THE RIVAL ROSES: YORK VERSUS LANCASTER

The Wars of the Roses (1455–1485) were a thirty-year series of bloody, dynastic civil wars fought between two rival branches of the royal Plantagenet dynasty: the **House of Lancaster** (red rose) and the **House of York** (white rose).

At the root of the catastrophe was the tragic personal weakness of King Henry VI. Gentle, pious, and mentally fragile, Henry suffered complete catatonic mental breakdowns, staring blankly at walls for over a year at a time. Nature abhors a power vacuum, and medieval England abhorred a king who could not lead soldiers in battle. Into the void stepped ambitious aristocratic lords who practiced **Bastard Feudalism**: instead of traditional feudal military dues, wealthy nobles used their vast fortunes to pay cash retaining fees to maintain private armies of liveried soldiers, using their armed thugs to intimidate judges, seize rival manors, and treat the English Crown as a prize to be won on the battlefield.

2 THE PRINCES IN THE TOWER: RICHARD'S RISE TO POWER

The conflict was marked by breathtaking aristocratic treachery and savage violence. At the **Battle of Towton** on Palm Sunday 1461, fought in a blinding snowstorm in Yorkshire, over 28,000 men were slaughtered in a single afternoon—the bloodiest single day ever recorded on English soil. Dynastic alliances shifted constantly: Richard Neville, Earl of Warwick—known as "The Kingmaker"—deposed two kings before being hunted down and killed in battle.

In April 1483, Yorkist King Edward IV died suddenly at forty-one, leaving behind two young sons: twelve-year-old Edward V and nine-year-old Richard, Duke of York. Their uncle, **Richard, Duke of Gloucester**, was appointed Lord Protector. Within months, Richard seized the young princes, housed them inside the royal apartments of the Tower of London, had Parliament declare them illegitimate, and crowned himself King Richard III. Late that summer, the two boys vanished behind the Tower's thick stone walls, never to be seen alive again. Rumours of their murder alienated Richard's closest allies and united both Yorkists and Lancastrians behind an obscure Welsh exile living in Brittany: **Henry Tudor**.

SOURCE B

CONTEMPORARY CHRONICLER

1483

Source A: An extract from the contemporary account 'How Richard III Made Himself King' by the Italian traveler Dominic Mancini, written in the summer of 1483.

"I have seen many men burst forth into tears and lamentations when mention was made of him [Edward V] after his removal from men's sight; and already there was a suspicion that he had been done away with. Whether, however, he has been done away with, and by what manner of death, so far I have not at all discovered."

Mancini was in London in 1483 and recorded the rumors and panic surrounding the sudden confinement and disappearance of Edward IV's young sons in the Tower of London.

PROVENANCE CLUE: Mancini was an independent Italian observer with no personal political stake in the English royal succession, making his contemporary observations about public panic and the princes' confinement highly reliable, although he could only report on rumours of their deaths rather than direct proof.

Primary Forensic Source

Ecclesiastical & Royal Dispatch

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

Bastard Feudalism: The late-medieval practice where wealthy lords paid cash retaining fees to contract private armies of liveried soldiers.

Usurpation: The act of seizing the sovereign royal throne by military force or conspiracy without a direct lawful hereditary claim.

Livery and Maintenance: The unlawful aristocratic practice of providing private badges to thugs and intimidating royal judges to protect retainers.

Tudor Settlement: The political compromise in 1485 where Henry VII married Elizabeth of York, combining the rival roses and ending civil war.

3 THE BATTLE OF BOSWORTH FIELD: THE END OF THE MIDDLE AGES

On 22 August 1485, the medieval era in England ended in blood and mud at the **Battle of Bosworth Field**. Richard III drew up his royal army on Ambion Hill, outnumbering Tudor two to one. But half of the royal forces were commanded by Lord Thomas Stanley and the Earl of Northumberland, who stood impassively on adjacent hills, waiting to see which side would gain the upper hand.

Recognizing he had been betrayed, Richard spotted Henry Tudor standing lightly guarded in the rear. In one of the most famous cavalry charges in British history, Richard lowered his lance and galloped headlong into Tudor's bodyguard. Richard killed Tudor's giant standard-bearer Sir William Brandon and unhorsed a colossal knight with his broadsword, fighting within inches of Henry's throat. At that decisive moment, Lord Stanley unleashed his 3,000 fresh troops into Richard's flank. Surrounded and dragged from his horse, Richard was hacked to death in the marsh, shouting *"Treason! Treason!"*

Richard's battered gold battle circlet was plucked from a hawthorn bush and placed upon the head of Henry Tudor as King Henry VII. By marrying Elizabeth of York, Henry united the red and white roses into the red-and-white Tudor rose, outlawed private noble retainers, and brought the bloody medieval era to a permanent close.

SOURCE C RENAISSANCE BATTLE RECORD

Published 1534

Polydore Vergil: The Death of Richard III at Bosworth Field



"King Richard, alone, was killed fighting manfully in the thickest press of his enemies... He rushed into the midst of the foe, killed William Brandon the standard-bearer, unhorsed John Cheney, and fought hand to hand until overwhelmed by numbers. Henry was proclaimed king on the field with Richard's battered crown."

Commissioned by King Henry VII (Henry Tudor) to record official Tudor history; highly critical of Richard's tyranny but unable to deny his battlefield valour.

HINGE QUESTION: Why was it vital for Henry VII to portray Richard III as an illegitimate monster rather than an anointed king?

Polydore Vergil • Anglica Historia (Book XXV)

Official Tudor Chronicle Record

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY 22 August 1485 • Market Bosworth & August 2012 • Leicester

POLYDORE VERGIL • ANGLICA HISTORIA & UNIVERSITY OF LEICESTER (2012)

THE CROWN IN A HAWTHORN BUSH & THE KING UNDER THE CAR PARK

The death of the medieval era was as dramatic as it was undignified. At Bosworth Field in August 1485, seeing his rearguard under the treacherous Lord Stanley refuse to fight, Richard III launched a heroic, suicidal cavalry charge directly at Henry Tudor. Richard killed Tudor's giant standard-bearer and fought within sword's reach of Henry before being surrounded and hacked to death in the boggy marsh, his heavy gold battle circlet knocked off his helmet and later retrieved from a thorny hawthorn bush. Stripped naked, slung over a horse, and buried in an unadorned grave at Greyfriars Priory in Leicester, Richard's memory was rewritten by Tudor propagandists as a deformed child-murdering villain. Five hundred and twenty-seven years later, in August 2012, archaeologists dug through the asphalt of a Leicester city council parking lot and uncovered his curved spine directly beneath parking bay letter "R"—complete with eleven battle wounds and a dagger thrust through his skull.



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE KING RICHARD III

Last Plantagenet King of England (Reigned 1483–1485) (1452–1485)

His usurpation of the throne and the mysterious disappearance of the Princes in the Tower alienated Yorkist allies, leading to his dramatic death at Bosworth.

- Served loyally as Lord of the North for his brother Edward IV, establishing a reputation for military courage and fairness.
- Seized the young Edward V on his way to his coronation in 1483, declared his nephews illegitimate, and took the crown for himself.
- Cut down in a desperate, ferocious cavalry charge targeting Henry Tudor at the Battle of Bosworth Field on 22 August 1485.

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: How did the system of "Bastard Feudalism" (paying cash retainers for private noble armies) cause the Wars of the Roses?

2. Causation: Explain why the disappearance of the Princes in the Tower fatally weakened Richard III's hold on the English throne.

3. Judgement: Why is the Battle of Bosworth Field (1485) considered by historians to mark the end of the Middle Ages in England?

ENQUIRY 9 • CORE SPECIFICATION THEME

LESSON 9: ASSESSMENT: HOW POWERFUL WAS A MEDIEVAL MONARCH?

1 BLOCK 1: HISTORICAL INTERPRETATIONS

Read the two historical interpretations below regarding the power of medieval monarchs. Consider what they focus on and how they differ.

2 INTERPRETATION A: ABSOLUTE NORMAN POWER

Interpretation A: The Absolute Feudal Sovereign

According to this interpretation, medieval monarchs held near-absolute dominance over England. Following 1066, William the Conqueror established a centralized feudal state backed by stone castles, ruthless scorched-earth terror (the Harrying of the North), and the all-seeing bureaucratic surveillance of the Domesday Book. Monarchs claimed Divine Right—authority derived directly from Almighty God—and commanded military resources, justice, and taxation that no individual subject could openly challenge for four centuries.

SOURCE B

CONTEMPORARY CHRONICLER

Historical Record

Interpretation A: A modern historian writing about the early Norman period.

"William the Conqueror's power was absolute. He ruled through fear and administration. With castles dominating every town and the Domesday Book recording every pig and cow, resistance was impossible."

Focuses entirely on the strength of William I and the immediate aftermath of 1066.

Primary Forensic Source

Ecclesiastical & Royal Dispatch

TASK 2 • CORE DISCIPLINARY VOCABULARY

Key Terms for Historical Argumentation

Royal Prerogative: The traditional discretionary rights and powers possessed exclusively by the monarch without parliamentary consent.

Constitutional Monarchy: A system of government where the sovereign monarch's power is strictly limited by the rule of law and parliamentary consent.

Feudal Inquest: A formal royal investigation into the wealth, property rights, and military obligations of subjects across the realm.

Sovereignty: The supreme, ultimate authority to govern, enact laws, levy taxes, and wage war within a territorial state.

3 INTERPRETATION B: A FRAGILE CROWN

Interpretation B: The Constrained and Fragile Crown

According to this interpretation, royal power was an illusion, permanently constrained by economic weakness, baronial resistance, and the universal authority of the Catholic Church. Medieval kings possessed no standing army and had to beg Parliament for taxation. When monarchs abused their prerogative, the results were catastrophic: Henry II was forced to submit to public whipping after Becket's murder; King John was humiliated at Runnymede and forced to seal Magna Carta; Richard II was challenged by 60,000 peasants in 1381; and the Wars of the Roses demonstrated that overmighty barons commanding private liveried armies could depose kings and butcher royal princes at will.

SOURCE C CONSTITUTIONAL TREATISE

Written c. 1471

Sir John Fortescue: The Governance of England

"The King of England cannot rule his people by other laws than such as they themselves assent unto... He cannot at his pleasure lay taxes upon them, nor alter their laws, without the consent of the whole realm in Parliament assembled. This is a political and royal dominion, far superior to absolute tyranny."

Written by the former Lord Chief Justice of the King's Bench during the Wars of the Roses, contrasting English limited monarchy against French royal absolutism.

HINGE QUESTION: How does Fortescue's fifteenth-century view of monarchy differ from William the Conqueror's rule in 1066?

Sir John Fortescue • Chief Justice of the King's Bench

Constitutional Analysis of the English Crown

ARCHIVAL ODDITY & CURIOUS REALITY 1066–1485 Historical Synthesis

HENRY DE BRACON • DE LEGIBUS ET CONSUEUDINIBUS ANGLIAE (C. 1235)

THE CROWN ON A TIGHTROPE: DIVINE RIGHT ON AN EMPTY STOMACH

The greatest irony of medieval English history is that monarchs claimed to rule by absolute Divine Right—anoointed with holy oils by the Archbishop as God's representative on earth—yet spent their entire lives walking an impossible political tightrope. A medieval king had no permanent police force, no standing professional army, and no modern central bank. If he ran out of money, he had to beg his barons for cash; if he fought a war, he had to rely on knights who might decide mid-battle to switch sides (as Lord Stanley did to Richard III at Bosworth). Kings who forgot this reality and acted like absolute tyrants (John, Edward II, Richard II) ended up cornered in muddy meadows, deposed, starved in dungeon basements, or murdered with red-hot pokers. Successful kings (William I, Edward I, Henry V) realized that real power was not about being feared in isolation, but about forging a ruthless partnership with the Church and the nobility.



KEY HISTORICAL FIGURE

KING EDWARD I ("LONGSHANKS")

King of England, Lord of Ireland & Duke of Aquitaine (1272–1307) (1239–1307)

The archetype of a successful medieval monarch; combined ferocious military power with regular parliamentary taxation to build English statehood.

- Summoned the "Model Parliament" in 1295, declaring: "What touches all should be approved by all" to raise taxes for his wars.
- Crushed Welsh independence and constructed an "iron ring" of state-of-the-art concentric stone castles (Caernarfon, Conwy, Harlech).
- Demonstrated that a king was most powerful not when ruling as a lone tyrant, but when consulting his barons and commons in Parliament.

4 BLOCK 2: PLANNING YOUR ESSAY

Use this block to plan your final assessment essay. A good history essay uses a clear structure, such as PEEL (Point, Evidence, Explain, Link).

Paragraph 1: Early Norman Power

How did early monarchs show their strength? (Hint: Think about William I, castles, and the Domesday Book).

Paragraph 2: The Church and Barons

How was royal power challenged by the Church and wealthy lords? (Hint: Think about Thomas Becket, and King John sealing Magna Carta).

Paragraph 3: Peasants and Civil War

How was the crown threatened by the lower classes and dynastic rivalries? (Hint: Think about the Peasants' Revolt in 1381 and the Wars of the Roses).

DISCIPLINARY ENQUIRY DECK • HISTORICAL VERDICT & SYNTHESIS

1. Analysis: Compare how William I maintained royal control in 1066 with how King John lost control in 1215.

2. Causation: Which social group posed the greatest continuous threat to royal power: the Catholic Church, the Barons, or the Peasantry?

3. Judgement: "A medieval monarch was only as powerful as their barons allowed them to be." Reach a final reasoned historical judgement.

MEDIEVAL ENGLAND • CHRONOLOGY & DISCIPLINARY GUIDE

Master Sequence of Events, Core Terminology & Historical Analysis Framework

MASTER CHRONOLOGICAL SEQUENCE (1066-1485)

5 Jan 1066: Edward the Confessor dies; Harold Godwinson crowned.	20 Sept 1066: Battle of Gate Fulford; Vikings defeat northern earls.	25 Sept 1066: Battle of Stamford Bridge; Harold defeats Hardrada.
14 Oct 1066: Battle of Hastings; William of Normandy defeats Harold.	25 Dec 1066: William crowned at Westminster Abbey amid panic and fires.	1069-1070: Harrying of the North; 100,000 perish in scorched-earth terror.
1086: The Domesday Survey completed; nationwide fiscal audit recorded.	25 Nov 1120: White Ship disaster drowns Prince William; leads to The Anarchy.	19 Dec 1154: Henry II ascends throne, establishing Angevin legal reforms.
29 Dec 1170: Archbishop Thomas Becket murdered in Canterbury Cathedral.	12 July 1174: Henry II undergoes barefoot public scourging at Canterbury.	1204: King John loses Normandy; begins extortionate scutage taxation.
15 June 1215: Magna Carta sealed at Runnymede, binding the Crown by law.	Nov 1295: Edward I summons Model Parliament ("What touches all...").	1348-1350: Black Death arrives; 30-45% die; feudal labor crisis erupts.
1351: Statute of Labourers attempts to freeze peasant wages at 1346 rates.	June 1381: Peasants' Revolt storms London; Tyler slain at Smithfield.	1455: Wars of the Roses ignite between Lancaster and York.
29 Mar 1461: Battle of Towton; bloodiest clash in snow with 28,000 dead.	June 1483: Princes in the Tower vanish; Richard III usurps the throne.	22 Aug 1485: Richard III slain at Bosworth; Henry VII begins Tudor dynasty.

CORE SPECIFICATION DISCIPLINARY GLOSSARY

Feudalism Hierarchical social contract: land exchanged for military service.	Benefit of Clergy Privilege of churchmen to be tried only in lenient canon courts.	Scutage Cash "shield tax" paid by barons to excuse feudal military duty.	Due Process Constitutional principle: no free man punished without lawful trial.
Demesne Land kept by manorial lord for private use using forced serf labor.	Miasma Medieval belief that bad smells and poisoned air caused pestilence.	Bastard Feudalism Late-medieval practice of paying cash retainers for private noble armies.	Sovereignty Supreme legal authority to enact law, levy taxes, and govern the realm.

KEY CONCEPTUAL THREADS FOR KS3 HISTORICAL EXPLANATION

1 • Feudal Hierarchy The pyramid of land, military dues, and oaths connecting King, Barons, Knights, and Villeins.	2 • Crown vs Church The permanent tension between royal courts and canon law over taxes, criminous clerks, and papal authority.	3 • Peasant Agency How the 1348 Black Death created labor scarcity, empowering serfs to challenge villeinage in 1381.	4 • Royal Limits Why claiming Divine Right meant nothing without money; how bad kings faced Magna Carta and civil war.
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KEY HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES ON MEDIEVAL ROYAL POWER

Whig Interpretation (The March of Liberty): Celebrates Magna Carta (1215) and the Model Parliament (1295) as the heroic, inevitable birth of English constitutional democracy and the rule of law over royal tyranny.

Revisionist & Social Interpretation: Emphasizes that medieval politics was driven by cynical aristocratic self-interest, financial extortion, and factional vendettas that left 85% of ordinary peasant serfs completely disenfranchised.